

PPFA

Research and Policy Team Retreat

Retreat Outline



WOMEN'S BRAIN TRUST

PAIN POINTS

We gathered a picture of where the team is now.

We synthesized the feedback we received from the survey and identified six pressure points that will be present, whether or not they're named.

01

STRUCTURAL

Change imposed from above

The reorganization felt done to the team, not with the team. No input. No co-design. Staff departures happening in silence breeds anxiety and job insecurity.

02

IDENTITY

Not one team yet

Almost no one identifies with the R&P team. People don't know each other's names, roles, or daily realities. Remote staff feel invisible and worry others don't see their work.

03

VISION

Talking points without meaning

Nearly half can't say what the vision means for their day-to-day. Heard it. Can't live it. Some feel that their attempts to live it have been sidelined.

04

LEADERSHIP & TRUST

Unprocessed pain is present

The interim VP situation, a key departure, favoritism, and perceived promotion inequity sit in the room, named or not.

05

RECOGNITION

Invisible labor, stalled growth

Directors carrying outsized workloads without title changes or recognition while watching others advance.

06

COLLABORATION

Territorial across EA

Cross-EA work feels like "hunger games." R&P is routed around, not sought out. Ownership disputes block progress.



WHAT WE HEARD

The team doesn't yet know what it means to work together

The vision exists but hasn't landed in day-to-day work

Pain is present and will be in the room whether named or not

People want connection, not just co-existence

The team is ready — they just need a reason to cohere

*so we designed
a retreat that...*

WHAT WE PLANNED

Names the hard stuff. Acknowledgment comes first, without defensiveness.

Answers the question the team hasn't answered yet: what is our cumulative value, together?

Builds identity from the inside out. Not handed down, but co-created and discovered in the room.

Creates real ways of working, not a document that lives in a drawer.

RETREAT PURPOSE STATEMENT

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To answer, together for the first time, what our cumulative value is as research and data experts, federal and state policy experts and strategists, and sex education experts – and to build the identity and ways of working that let us deliver on it.

This statement is specific enough to be argued with, and that tension is the point.

Priya Parker calls this "disputable purpose," we call it resistance. It's what creates the possibility that time together can change a team's dynamic.



Each of the following objectives names a step toward the purpose.

01	VISION Make the vision real.	Close the gap between talking points and day-to-day meaning through concrete conversation and interaction.
02	WAYS OF WORKING Build shared agreements and a plan to actually use them.	Commit to norms the team can hold each other to, not a document that lives in a drawer.
03	IDENTITY Name who you are as R&P and Education.	Collective identity has to be discovered in the room. Build it together, not handed down from above.
04	COLLABORATION Strengthen the muscle to work across workstreams and EA.	Name and experiment with collaboration at two levels: within R&P, and in order to represent yourselves with External Affairs broadly.
05	ACKNOWLEDGMENT Acknowledge what this team has been through.	Name the hard stuff, without defensiveness.

These principles shape every session, and the experience as a whole.

Priya Parker's Disputable Purpose

Every design decision is tested against the retreat purpose. If a session doesn't serve the purpose, it doesn't belong.

Gestalt / Cape Cod Method

Awareness before action. Solo → pairs → small groups → full group. The relational ground of Day 1 makes Day 2's substantive work possible.

Name Wall

A shared physical space that accumulates across both days for observations, needs, offers, and 'I See You' statements. It anchors the Day 2 close.

Two Rounds of Vision Articulations

Stephanie shares her vision twice - once when the team is relationally warm, once when they're ready to do something with it. The second is a response to what she heard.

Collaboration Ideas Chart

Open from Day 1, created by the team in real time, brought to life on Day 2 in an open fishbowl. The ideas belong to the team, not the agenda.

Pre-Work Drives Pairings

Each person identifies who they know least. We'll share back those responses so people can prioritize the low-familiarity connections for walks and talks/small groups.

We're working toward a purposeful sequence, not a packed agenda.

DAY ONE

Arrival, Awareness & Who We Are

The purpose of Day 1 is relational and awareness-building. Before the team can do substantive work together, they need to know each other - not just by role, but by what they carry, what they need, and how they're wired.

- Name what's true about the moment this team is in
- Test the retreat purpose against their own experience
- Begin to see each other's actual work and actual needs
- Hear Stephanie's vision and respond to it honestly

DAY TWO

Substance, Vision & What We Build Together

On Day 2, the team moves from knowing each other to building something more concrete together - identity, agreements, and real collaboration ideas. This is possible because of the relational work built in Day 1.

- Map what each workstream does and what it needs from the others
- Discover what only this team can do at the intersection
- Return to and wrestle with the retreat purpose statement
- Commit to real norms, routines & rituals — and collaborative ideas in real time

Arrival, Awareness & Who We Are

9:30	Threshold Opening Two-word check-in: how you're arriving, how you hope to leave. Sets the tone for everything. Introduce the Name Wall + Collaboration Ideas Chart.	30 min
10:00	Stephanie Opens Two components: (1) acknowledges what the team has been through (without defending); (2) introduces the retreat purpose statement as the reason they're here.	20 min
10:20	Purpose Walk and Talk Cross-workstream pairs walk with two questions: honest reaction to the purpose; what would need to be true for it to feel real in 6 months.	40 min
11:00	Purpose Conversation (Full Group) Open conversation about what surfaced.	35 min
11:35	Break	15 min
11:50	The Work I Do and Want You To See Individual writing then small group shares. Each group adds observations to each other's Name Wall spots — first contributions to the wall.	40 min
12:30	Lunch	60 min

Arrival, Awareness & Who We Are

1:30	Prism Primer	20 min
Brief framework introduction for the full group. Goal: shared vocabulary, not a full debrief.		
1:50	Prism Pairs Walk Outside	35 min
Walk prompts: how you work, where you're alive or depleted, what you need from this team.		
2:25	Prism Constellation + What I Need... / What I Offer...	40 min
Human constellation mapping personalities and personalities under pressure. Each person writes two cards — needs and offers — and posts them to their Name Wall spot. Silent gallery walk, then full group debrief.		
3:05	Stephanie's Vision (First Articulation)	20 min
Stephanie shares her vision for R&P + facilitated discussion with full team.		
3:25	Day 1 Close	15 min
Popcorn round: 'Something I learned about someone today I didn't know before.' Reminder that the Name Wall and Collaboration Chart are open. Preview of Day 2.		

Substance, Vision & What We Build Together

9:30	Opening Day 2 5 minutes of individual writing before sharing as a whole.	15 min
9:45	Stephanie's Vision (Second Articulation) Not a repeat, but a response shaped by everything heard on Day 1.	20 min
10:05	Workstream Mapping - What We Do and What We Need Each workstream answers: what we actually do, what we need from others, what we offer. Presentations, cross-workstream responses, facilitators map interdependencies.	60 min
11:05	Break	10 min
11:15	Only R&P Can... (What's Possible at the Intersections) Mixed groups answer: what can this team do that no other team at PPFA can? Specific, concrete examples only. Stephanie responds last – connecting what she heard to her vision.	45 min
12:00	Return to the Purpose Statement With everything generated, return to the purpose. Does it feel true now? Has language shifted? Close: what do you understand about this team that you didn't 36 hours ago?	30 min
12:30	Lunch	60 min

1:30

Ways of Working / Norms, Routines & Rituals

65 min

Brief intro of WBT's Norms/Routines/Rituals framework. Small cross-functional groups identify specific norms, routines, and rituals that would support this team. Full group narrows to 2–3 real commitments across each. Stephanie and the team name what they'll hold each other to.

2:35

Collaboration in Action

40 min

Revisit the Collaboration Ideas Chart — open since Day 1. Whoever is energized by an idea self-selects into the center (open fishbowl). Each idea gets 10–12 minutes: what is it, who owns it, what's the first step, and what norms/routines/rituals does it need? Repeat with 2–3 ideas.

3:15

Closing

25 min

Time for reflection at the wall — folks read everything accumulated over two days. Popcorn round: 'I'm walking away with ____.' Stephanie closes last: names individual contributions she witnessed, needs she saw named, what becomes possible in the work together.

What the team carries back to work.

01 Answered purpose

A shared understanding of this team's cumulative value — what research, policy, and education can do together that none could do alone.

02 Named identity

A team that has begun to discover who it is — not just who its members were before they got here.

03 2–3 real working agreements

Specific norms, routines, and rituals organized by WBT's resilience framework. Typed and distributed within 48 hours.

04 Live collaboration ideas

2–3 cross-workstream collaboration ideas with named owners and first steps — developed in the open fishbowl on Day 2.

05 The Name Wall

A physical artifact of being seen — observations, needs, offers, and 'I See You' statements that accumulated across both days.

06 A new starting point

Stephanie's vision — heard twice, wrestled with, and connected to what the team itself identified as possible.

Thank you!

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